



Detail Valley
Mobile Detailing · Valley County

THE COMPLETE FIELD HANDBOOK

Detailing, Start to Finish.

Every plan, every step, every tool — written for someone who has never detailed a car before. Follow the list, deliver the result.

Express · Full Detail · Showroom · Add-ons

We come to you

Contents

The Detail Valley mobile detailing handbook

- 01 How to use this handbook 3
- 02 Safety first 4
- 03 Before every job — setup & walk-around 5
- 04 Core skills — the techniques every detail uses 6
- 05 Express Detail — full walkthrough (\$60, ~1 hr) 10
- 06 Full Detail — full walkthrough (\$150, ~3 hrs) 13
- 07 Showroom Detail — full walkthrough (\$275, ~5 hrs) 16
- 08 Add-on services — step by step 19
- 09 Vehicle size & dirt — adjusting the job 21
- 10 Common mistakes & how to fix them 22
- 11 Customer aftercare — what to tell them 23
- 12 Glossary 24
- 13 Quick-reference cards 25

01 START HERE How to use this handbook

This is the complete playbook for detailing a car the Detail Valley way — written for someone who has **never cleaned a car professionally before**. If you can follow a numbered list, you can deliver every package in here.

The book is in three parts. **Foundations** (Chapters 2–4) teach the safety rules and the core skills — the two-bucket wash, claying, machine polishing, the extractor and so on. **The Plans** (Chapters 5–8) are start-to-finish, step-by-step instructions for Express, Full Detail, Showroom and every add-on. **Reference** (Chapters 9–13) covers pricing by vehicle size, fixing mistakes, customer aftercare, a glossary and quick-reference cards.

Each step tells you three things: the **tools/items** to grab, **exactly how** to do it, and the **mistake to avoid** — plus a "done when" so you know when to move on.

First time out. Read Chapters 2, 3 and 4 fully before your first paid job, then practise an Express on your own car. Once that feels natural, the bigger packages are just the same skills in a longer order.

If you remember nothing else

- **Wheels and tires first** — they are the dirtiest part of the car.
- **Top-to-bottom outside, cleanest-to-dirtiest inside.**
- **Two buckets, grit guards, separate mitts** — this is how you avoid putting swirls in the paint.
- **Always work in the shade** on a cool panel. Sun bakes product on and leaves spots.
- **Let products dwell.** Sprays need time to work — don't scrub them off early.
- **Use less than you think.** Thin layers of wax, dressing and coating are easier and look better.
- **Decontaminate before you protect** — iron remover and clay before any wax, sealant or coating.

02 FOUNDATIONS

Safety first

Detailing uses strong chemicals, water, electricity and a lot of bending. None of it is dangerous if you respect it. Read this once and build the habits.

Chemicals

- Wear **nitrile gloves** for wheel cleaning, iron removal, correction and coatings.
- Use **eye protection** with iron/fallout removers and degreasers — they sting and smell strong.
- **Never mix products** in one bottle. Some combinations make harmful gas.
- Work **ventilated**; keep lids on; **label every spray bottle** with the product and dilution.
- Keep all chemicals away from kids and pets, and out of the sun in the van.

Water + electricity

- Keep the **generator or power station dry** and away from the wash area.
- Use a **GFCI** outlet/adaptor for the vacuum, extractor and polisher.
- Never run a corded tool through a puddle; route cords away from runoff.

Your body & the site

- Use a **kneeling pad** for wheels and interiors; lift mats and tanks with your legs.
- Watch for **slips** — soapy concrete is like ice. Keep your path clear.
- Control your **runoff** so soap doesn't flow into storm drains or a neighbour's yard.
- Photograph any **existing damage** with the customer before you start — it protects you both.

Hot surfaces. Never apply wash, wheel cleaner, iron remover, wax or coating to a hot, sun-baked panel or wheel. Move to shade and let it cool, or you'll get streaks, stains and water spots.

03 FOUNDATIONS

Before every job — setup & walk-around

A smooth job starts before you touch the car. Five minutes of setup saves you an hour of problems.

1. **Confirm the booking.** Package, any add-ons, and the vehicle size (car / SUV / oversized). Quote add-ons and size surcharge up front so there are no surprises at payment.
2. **Position the car.** Park in shade or move into it. You need room to walk all the way around and to open every door.
3. **Protect the surroundings.** Mind where water will run, and keep foam/over-spray off the customer's house, plants and the car beside it.
4. **Set up the rig.** Connect your water tank/pump and pressure washer, load the foam cannon, lay out buckets, set up power for the vacuum and extractor, and lay a mat for your tools.
5. **Walk around with the customer.** Note and photograph existing scratches, dents, chips, stains and trim damage. Set expectations (e.g. "a one-step polish removes most light swirls, not deep scratches").
6. **Clear the interior.** Remove personal items into a tray, and bag the loose trash. Pull the floor mats out.
7. **Make a plan.** Wheels → exterior → protect → interior → glass → final. Picture the order before you start.

Before-photos. Take a quick set of "before" photos of the whole car and any damage. They protect you from disputes and they are great marketing for your "after" shots.

04 FOUNDATIONS

Core skills — the techniques every detail uses

Master these once and every package becomes easy. The plans in Chapters 5–8 refer back to these skills, so learn them here.

The order of operations (why order matters)

Always work **dirtiest-to-cleanest** and **top-to-bottom**. Wheels and tires are filthiest, so they come first — before your wash water and mitts are clean. The body washes top-to-bottom because dirt runs down. Inside, you vacuum and dust before you wet-clean, and you do glass **last** so nothing over-sprays onto it.

Foam pre-wash

TOOLS / ITEMS **Pressure washer** **Foam cannon** **pH-neutral shampoo**

The pre-wash removes as much dirt as possible **before** anything touches the paint, so your mitt drags less grit. Rinse the whole car top-to-bottom first. Load the foam cannon with shampoo to the label's ratio, coat the car in thick foam, and let it **dwelt 2–3 minutes** (never in direct sun) to soften and loosen grime. Then rinse it off.

No pressure washer? A pump sprayer with diluted shampoo, or a good rinse with a hose, still helps.

The two-bucket contact wash

TOOLS / ITEMS **2 buckets + grit guards** **Wash mitt(s)** **pH-neutral shampoo**

This is the single most important habit for swirl-free paint. Fill one bucket with shampoo solution and one with clean rinse water; drop a grit guard in each. Wash **one panel at a time, top to bottom**, using straight back-and-forth strokes — **never circles**. After every panel, dunk the mitt in the **rinse** bucket and scrub it on the grit guard to release dirt, then reload from the **soap** bucket. Use a separate mitt for the lower, dirtiest sections (rockers, bumpers).

Let the mitt glide — no pressure. The soap does the work.

Drop the mitt on the ground? Rinse it thoroughly before it touches paint again.

Rinsing & drying without swirls

TOOLS / ITEMS **Hose / pressure washer** **2 plush drying towels** **Optional blower**

Rinse top-to-bottom until no suds remain, flushing soap out of door shuts, the grille, badges and mirror bases where it hides. To dry, **pat and drag** a plush waffle/twist-loop towel gently — use a second towel for the lower half, and blow or wick water out of mirrors, badges and trim gaps so it doesn't run out and streak later.

Drying in the sun causes water spots — stay in shade and work quickly.

Wash drying towels separately and never use fabric softener (it kills absorbency).

Chemical decontamination (iron remover)

TOOLS / ITEMS

Iron/fallout remover

Gloves + eye protection

Over time, tiny metal particles from brakes and rail dust embed in the paint and feel rough. With the car still wet after washing, spray iron remover over the paint and wheels; it **bleeds purple** as it dissolves the metal. Let it dwell per the label (about 3–5 minutes, never letting it dry), agitate heavy spots lightly, then rinse thoroughly.

Strong smell — gloves, eye protection and good airflow.

Do this before clayling; it makes the clay last longer.

Clay bar

TOOLS / ITEMS

Clay bar

Clay lube (or rinseless solution)

Microfiber

Clay pulls out the bonded contaminants a wash leaves behind (run the back of your hand over washed paint through a sandwich bag — if it feels gritty, it needs clay). Spray **lots of lube** on one panel, then glide the clay **flat** with light pressure in straight lines. It grabs at first, then goes smooth. Wipe the panel, fold the clay to a fresh face when it greys, and work every painted panel and the glass.

Never clay a dry panel — always plenty of lube, or you'll mar the paint.

If the clay hits the ground, throw it away — trapped grit will scratch.

Interior cleaning with APC & brushes

TOOLS / ITEMS

All-purpose cleaner (APC)

Detailing brushes

Detailing swabs

Microfiber

Dilute APC to strength (stronger for carpet and rubber, weaker for soft-touch plastics). **Spray onto the brush or towel, not the surface**, then agitate door panels, vents, the console, cupholders, buttons and seams; use swabs in the vent slats. Wipe away residue with a clean damp towel, then a dry one.

Always test a hidden spot first.

Never use APC on real leather — it dries it out and cracks it.

Use a soft brush on glossy piano-black trim; stiff bristles scratch it.

Vacuuming properly

TOOLS / ITEMS

Wet/dry vacuum

Crevice + brush tools

Pull and shake the floor mats and vacuum both sides, then set them aside. Vacuum the seats (including between and under), carpets and trunk. Use the **crevice tool** for seat rails and seams, and the **brush head** for cloth and panels. **Agitate carpet with a stiff brush first** to lift ground-in dirt, then vacuum it up.

Carpet extractor

TOOLS / ITEMS

Carpet extractor

Upholstery shampoo

Brush

Fan

An extractor sprays cleaning solution into fabric and sucks the dirty water back out. Pre-treat stains, spray/inject shampoo, agitate with a brush, then run **overlapping wet passes followed by dry passes** (suction only) to pull the moisture back out. Repeat heavy areas. Finish damp, **not soaked**, and dry with fans or cracked windows.

Over-wetting causes mildew and a lasting smell — restraint beats power.

Don't extract leather; clean and condition it instead.

Machine polishing 101 (one-step correction)

TOOLS / ITEMS

Dual-action (DA) polisher

Cutting & polishing pads

Compound / all-in-one

Panel-prep (IPA)

LED light

Painter's tape

A dual-action polisher gently removes a microscopic layer of clear coat to erase swirls and bring back gloss. It is **beginner-safe** because the pad oscillates rather than spinning aggressively. Tape off trim, badges and tight edges first. Prime the pad with a few drops of compound, spread it over a **2ft × 2ft section on speed 1**, then raise to **speed 4–5** and work the section with **slow, overlapping passes** (3–4 passes), keeping the **pad flat and always moving**. Wipe the residue and check under the LED at an angle. Repeat panel by panel.

Never tilt the pad or press hard — that causes holograms and can burn an edge.

Keep the pad moving; never let it sit spinning in one spot.

Work in shade on cool paint, and keep pads clean — a clogged pad stops cutting.

Applying wax, sealant or ceramic spray

TOOLS / ITEMS

Wax / sealant / ceramic spray

Foam applicator

2 microfibers

Protection only bonds to **clean, decontaminated, oil-free paint**, so wipe corrected panels with panel-prep first. Working in shade on cool paint: for **wax/sealant**, spread a **thin, even** layer over one or two panels with the applicator, let it haze to a light cloud (a couple of minutes), then buff off with a plush towel and final-buff with a dry side. For **ceramic spray**, mist it on, spread evenly, and buff to clarity panel by panel.

Thin is everything — thick product is chalky and miserable to remove.

Keep wax off plastic trim; it leaves white stains.

Applying a ceramic coating (upgrade)

TOOLS / ITEMS

Ceramic coating kit

Applicator block + suede cloths

Panel-prep (IPA)

LED light

A coating is a semi-permanent layer that lasts 1–5 years. The paint **must be corrected and panel-wiped** first. Wrap a suede cloth on the applicator block, add a few drops, and apply to **one small section** in a **cross-hatch** (up-down then left-right). Let it **flash** (it goes rainbowy after ~30–90s — check the label), then **level it off** with a fresh microfiber until clear. Inspect under the LED for streaky "high spots" and buff them out before they cure.

Work in shade, small sections, and don't let a panel over-cure before levelling.

Keep the car dry for 24 hours after coating.

Glass — streak-free every time

TOOLS / ITEMS

Ammonia-free glass cleaner

2 waffle-weave towels

Do glass **last**. Spray cleaner **onto the towel** (not the glass in sun), wipe the window, then buff dry with a second waffle-weave towel. Roll front windows down an inch to clean the hidden top edge. Check each pane at an angle for streaks.

Keep glass towels separate — wax residue on them causes the streaks people blame on the cleaner.

Ammonia damages tint; always use an ammonia-free cleaner inside.

Dressings without sling or grease

TOOLS / ITEMS

Tire dressing

Trim/plastic dressing

Applicators

Dressings go on **clean, dry** surfaces. Apply **thin** with an applicator and **wipe the edge** so nothing slings onto the paint as the customer drives. For interior plastics, choose a **matte** finish and buff off the excess — glossy dressings cause windshield glare and attract dust.

05

THE PLANS • PLAN 1

Express Detail — full walkthrough (\$60, ~1 hr)

A fast exterior wash and interior refresh. The goal is a clean, bright car — not paint correction. Follow these in order.

1 Set up & inspect

TOOLS / ITEMS

Gloves

Tool mat

Phone (photos)

Trash bag

DO THIS Park in shade. Confirm the package and add-ons. Walk the car with the customer and photograph any existing scratches, dents or stains. Open all doors, pull the floor mats out, and bag the loose trash.

AVOID Starting on a hot, sun-baked panel — water and product flash-dry and leave spots.

DONE WHEN The cabin is clear of personal items and you have before-photos.

2 Wheels, tires & wheel wells

TOOLS / ITEMS

Acid-free wheel cleaner

Wheel brushes / woolies

Stiff tire brush

Hose / pressure washer

DO THIS Rinse each wheel, tire and wheel well to knock off loose grit. Spray wheel cleaner on a cool wheel and let it dwell ~30–60s. Agitate the face with a soft brush and the barrel/spokes with a woolie; scrub the tire and well with the stiff brush. Rinse until the water runs clear. Do all four before touching the body.

AVOID Using the same brush on wheels and paint, or cleaning a hot wheel (the cleaner can stain).

DONE WHEN No brown on the tires and no brake dust left in the spokes.

3 Pre-rinse & foam

TOOLS / ITEMS

Pressure washer

Foam cannon

pH-neutral shampoo

DO THIS Rinse the whole car top-to-bottom to float off loose dirt. Coat it in foam and let it dwell 2–3 minutes (not in sun) to soften the grime.

AVOID Letting the foam dry on the paint.

DONE WHEN The car is evenly covered and dirt is visibly loosening.

4 Two-bucket contact wash

TOOLS / ITEMS

2 buckets + grit guards

Wash mitt(s)

Shampoo

DO THIS Wash top-to-bottom, one panel at a time, with straight strokes. After each panel, rinse the mitt in the rinse bucket, scrub it on the grit guard, and reload from the soap bucket. Use a separate mitt for the lower, dirtiest sections.

AVOID Circular scrubbing, pressing hard, or reusing a dropped mitt — all add swirls.

DONE WHEN Every panel has been washed and the mitt re-soaped between them.

5 Final rinse & dry

TOOLS / ITEMS

Hose / pressure washer

2 drying towels

Optional blower

DO THIS Rinse top-to-bottom until no suds remain, flushing door shuts and badges. Pat-and-drag dry with a plush towel (second towel for the lower half) and blow water out of mirrors, grille and trim gaps.

AVOID Dragging a gritty towel or drying in direct sun (water spots).

DONE WHEN Paint, glass and trim are dry with no drips waiting to streak.

6 Tire shine

TOOLS / ITEMS

Tire dressing

Applicator

Microfiber

DO THIS Apply dressing thin and even to clean, dry tires with the applicator; wipe the edge so it won't sling. Wipe any over-spray off the wheel.

AVOID Globbing it on — excess slings onto the paint while driving.

DONE WHEN Tires are an even satin black with no runs.

7 Vacuum the interior

TOOLS / ITEMS

Wet/dry vacuum

Crevice + brush tools

DO THIS Vacuum both sides of the mats and set them aside. Vacuum the seats (including between and under), carpets and trunk; crevice tool for seat rails and seams.

AVOID Skipping under the seats and between the cushions.

DONE WHEN No visible debris and the carpets look refreshed.

8 Quick interior wipe

TOOLS / ITEMS

Light APC or quick-detailer

Microfiber

Soft brush

DO THIS Lightly mist a towel (not the screen) and wipe the dash, gauge cluster, vents (soft brush), console, cupholders, door tops and handles. Hit the touch points — wheel, shifter, buttons.

AVOID Spraying directly onto screens/electronics, or greasy dressings on the dash (glare).

DONE WHEN Surfaces are clean and matte, not greasy.

9 Glass — in & out

TOOLS / ITEMS

Ammonia-free glass cleaner

2 waffle-weave towels

DO THIS Spray cleaner on the towel and wipe each window, then buff dry with the second towel. Do the insides top-down, finish the mirrors, and drop the front windows an inch to get the top edge.

AVOID Cleaning glass in direct sun, or ammonia on tint.

DONE WHEN Glass is clear from every angle.

10 Reset & hand over

DO THIS Put the mats back, remove your gear, and scan for missed spots. Walk the finished car with the customer, collect payment, ask for a 5-star review and leave a card.

DONE WHEN The customer is happy and the cabin is at least as tidy as you found it.

Full Detail — full walkthrough (\$150, ~3 hrs)

Everything in Express, plus paint decontamination, a wax finish and a true interior deep-clean. This is your bread-and-butter package.

1 Set up, inspect & feel the paint

TOOLS / ITEMS **Gloves** **Phone** **Sandwich bag**

DO THIS Set up and do the customer walk-around and photos as in Express. Then rub a sandwich-bag-covered hand over a washed area later to judge how much decontamination it needs.

DONE WHEN You have before-photos and a plan for the paint.

2 Wheels, tires & wells

TOOLS / ITEMS **Wheel cleaner** **Wheel brushes** **Stiff tire brush**

DO THIS Clean all four wheels, tires and wells exactly as in Express, before touching the body.

DONE WHEN Wheels and tires are spotless.

3 Bug & sap/tar removal

TOOLS / ITEMS **Bug & tar remover** **Bug sponge / microfiber**

DO THIS Before the main wash, spray bug & tar remover on the bumper, mirrors and leading edges where bugs hit, plus any tar or tree-sap spots. Dwell 1–2 minutes and gently agitate with a dedicated sponge. The wash then carries it away.

AVOID Scrubbing dry or letting it bake in the sun.

DONE WHEN Bugs, tar and sap have lifted.

4 Foam pre-wash + two-bucket wash

TOOLS / ITEMS **Foam cannon** **2 buckets + grit guards** **Shampoo** **Mitts**

DO THIS Foam, dwell, then do the full two-bucket contact wash top-to-bottom (see Core Skills).

DONE WHEN The whole car has been safely contact-washed.

5 Iron / fallout decontamination

TOOLS / ITEMS **Iron remover** **Gloves + eye protection**

DO THIS With the car still wet, spray iron remover over the paint and wheels; let it bleed purple and dwell ~3–5 min without drying, then rinse thoroughly.

AVOID Applying to hot panels, letting it dry, or skipping eye protection.

DONE WHEN It rinses clean with no more purple bleeding.

6 Clay bar

TOOLS / ITEMS Clay bar Clay lube Microfiber

DO THIS Lube each panel generously and glide the clay flat in straight lines until the surface goes smooth; fold to a fresh face as it greys. Do every painted panel and the glass.

AVOID Claying a dry panel, or reusing dropped clay.

DONE WHEN The paint feels like glass everywhere.

7 Dry

TOOLS / ITEMS 2 drying towels Optional blower

DO THIS Rinse and dry top-to-bottom, blowing water out of trim gaps (see Core Skills).

DONE WHEN The car is fully dry and ready to wax.

8 Wax / protect

TOOLS / ITEMS Carnauba wax or sealant Foam applicator 2 microfibers

DO THIS In shade on cool, clean, dry paint, spread a thin even layer over one or two panels, let it haze to a light cloud, then buff off and final-buff with a dry side.

AVOID Thick layers, waxing plastic trim (white stains), or working in the sun.

DONE WHEN The paint is slick and glossy with no smears in the reflection.

9 Interior — declutter & deep vacuum

TOOLS / ITEMS Vacuum Stiff brush Crevice tool

DO THIS Remove mats and all trash. Vacuum seats, between and under cushions, carpets and trunk. Agitate carpet with a brush to lift ground-in dirt, then vacuum again.

DONE WHEN No debris remains anywhere in the cabin.

10 Interior — deep clean surfaces

TOOLS / ITEMS APC (diluted) Detailing brushes Swabs Microfiber

DO THIS Spray APC onto a brush/towel and clean door panels, vents (soft brush + swabs in the slats), console, cupholders, buttons, sun visors and seams. Wipe with a damp then dry towel.

AVOID Soaking electronics/screens, strong APC on leather, or scrubbing piano-black hard.

DONE WHEN Every touch surface and seam is clean.

11 Floor mats deep-clean

TOOLS / ITEMS

APC / mat cleaner

Stiff brush

Hose or extractor

DO THIS Rubber mats: spray, scrub, rinse, dry. Carpet mats: spray cleaner, agitate, then extract or rinse and stand them on edge to dry.

AVOID Putting carpet mats back wet (it causes odour).

DONE WHEN Mats are clean and nearly dry.

12 Condition plastics & glass

TOOLS / ITEMS

Matte interior dressing

Applicator

Glass cleaner

2 waffle towels

DO THIS Wipe a thin layer of matte conditioner onto the dash, doors and trim, then buff so it's dry to the touch. Finish with streak-free glass, inside and out.

AVOID Glossy dressing on the dash (windshield glare).

DONE WHEN Plastics look revived and glass is streak-free.

13 Door jambs, trim & hand-over

TOOLS / ITEMS

APC

Microfiber

Trim dressing

DO THIS Open each door; wipe the jambs and sills clean; lightly dress the seals and exterior trim. Then do the final walk-around, put mats back, take payment and ask for a review.

DONE WHEN Even the door jambs are clean — the detail people always notice.

Showroom Detail — full walkthrough (\$275, ~5 hrs)

Everything in Full Detail, plus a one-step paint correction, sealed protection, leather care and a full shampoo & extraction. This is the flagship — slow down and check your work under a light at every stage.

1 Set up & paint inspection

TOOLS / ITEMS

Gloves

LED inspection light

Phone

DO THIS Set up and do the walk-around/photos. Inspect the paint under the LED at an angle, note the swirls and scratches, and set expectations: a one-step polish removes most light defects, not deep scratches.

DONE WHEN You've mapped the paint's condition with the customer.

2 Wheels, tires & wells

TOOLS / ITEMS

Wheel cleaner

Brushes

Tire brush

DO THIS Clean all four wheels, tires and wells first.

DONE WHEN Wheels and tires are spotless.

3 Undercarriage / salt flush

TOOLS / ITEMS

Undercarriage cleaner or APC

Pressure washer

DO THIS Flush the wheel wells, rockers and underside to remove salt, mud and road film. In winter, apply a salt neutralizer, let it dwell, then rinse.

AVOID High pressure aimed straight at electrical connectors and sensors.

DONE WHEN The wells and underside run clean.

4 Bug/sap removal + wash

TOOLS / ITEMS

Bug & tar remover

Foam cannon

2 buckets

Mitts

DO THIS Treat bugs, tar and sap, then foam pre-wash and two-bucket contact wash top-to-bottom.

DONE WHEN The car is safely washed and contaminant-free on the surface.

5 Iron decon + clay

TOOLS / ITEMS

Iron remover

Clay bar

Clay lube

DO THIS Iron-remove (dwell, rinse), then clay every panel and the glass until glass-smooth.

DONE WHEN The paint is fully decontaminated and slick to the touch.

6 Dry & tape up

TOOLS / ITEMS

Drying towels

Painter's tape

DO THIS Dry fully, then mask rubber trim, plastic edges, badges and tight gaps the polisher could burn or stain.

AVOID Leaving tape on in the sun (it bakes on).

DONE WHEN Vulnerable edges are protected and the car is dry.

7 One-step paint correction

TOOLS / ITEMS

DA polisher

Cutting/polishing pads

Compound / all-in-one

LED light

DO THIS Prime the pad, spread product over a 2ft×2ft section on speed 1, then work it at speed 4–5 with 3–4 slow, overlapping passes, keeping the pad flat and moving. Wipe and check under the LED. Repeat panel by panel.

AVOID High pressure or a tilted pad (holograms), and working in the sun.

DONE WHEN Light swirls are gone and the gloss jumps under the light.

8 Panel-prep wipe-down

TOOLS / ITEMS

Panel-prep / IPA

Microfiber

DO THIS Wipe every corrected panel with panel-prep to remove polishing oils — oils hide defects and stop protection from bonding.

DONE WHEN The paint squeaks clean and the true finish is visible.

9 Apply protection + seal wheels

TOOLS / ITEMS

Sealant or ceramic spray

Wheel sealant

Applicators

DO THIS In shade, apply sealant thin and even (haze, then buff) or ceramic spray (mist, spread, buff to clarity), panel by panel. Then apply wheel sealant to clean, cool wheels and buff.

AVOID Applying over oily or un-prepped paint.

DONE WHEN Water beads tightly and the wheels are slick.

10 Interior — deep vacuum

TOOLS / ITEMS

Vacuum

Brush

Crevice tool

DO THIS Remove mats and trash; vacuum seats, crevices, under seats, carpets and trunk, agitating carpet first.

DONE WHEN The cabin is debris-free and ready for wet cleaning.

11 Shampoo & extract seats + carpets

TOOLS / ITEMS

Extractor

Upholstery shampoo

Brush

Fan

DO THIS Pre-treat stains, inject/spray shampoo, agitate, then run overlapping wet-then-dry passes to pull the moisture back out. Repeat heavy spots. Finish damp, not soaked, and set fans to dry.

AVOID Drenching the foam padding (mildew/odour), or extracting leather.

DONE WHEN The recovered water runs nearly clear and fabric is just damp.

12 Leather clean & condition

TOOLS / ITEMS

Leather cleaner

Soft leather brush

Leather conditioner

Microfiber

DO THIS Spray leather cleaner on a soft brush, gently lift dirt from the grain, and wipe. Once dry, apply conditioner thin, let it absorb a few minutes, then buff off the excess.

AVOID APC on leather, or soaking perforated leather (it clogs the holes).

DONE WHEN Leather is clean, supple and matte — not slippery.

13 Hard surfaces, jambs, trim & glass

TOOLS / ITEMS

APC

Brushes

Matte dressing

Glass cleaner

DO THIS Deep-clean and condition the plastics, clean and dress the door jambs and exterior trim, and finish streak-free glass inside and out.

DONE WHEN The whole interior is clean, conditioned and glare-free.

14 Final inspection & hand-over

TOOLS / ITEMS

LED light

DO THIS Set fans / crack windows to finish drying. Walk the car under the LED with the customer. Take payment, ask for a review, and explain any cure time if the paint was coated.

DONE WHEN The car looks showroom and the customer knows how to care for it.

08 THE PLANS • PLAN 4

Add-on services — step by step

Add-ons bolt onto any package. Quote the add-on price on top of the base package and the vehicle-size surcharge.

A Pet hair removal (+\$35)

TOOLS / ITEMS Rubber pet brush / pumice Vacuum Lint roller

DO THIS Drag the rubber brush or pumice over seats and carpet in one direction to ball the hair up, then vacuum. Repeat low-and-slow over stubborn areas, and lint-roll the edges, seams and headliner.

AVOID Expecting one pass to do it — embedded hair needs several.

DONE WHEN No hair lifts when you drag a clean rubber glove across the fabric.

B Seat shampoo (+\$45)

TOOLS / ITEMS Extractor or spray + brush Upholstery shampoo Stain pre-treat Fan

DO THIS Vacuum first and pre-treat stains. Spray shampoo, agitate with a brush, then extract until the water runs clear. Repeat heavy areas and set a fan to dry.

AVOID Over-wetting the foam padding.

DONE WHEN Seats are clean and only lightly damp.

C Engine bay clean (+\$30)

TOOLS / ITEMS Degreaser Brushes Plastic bags Engine dressing

DO THIS With the engine cool (not hot), cover the intake, alternator and fuse box with plastic. Spray degreaser, agitate with brushes, then rinse at LOW pressure. Blow/wipe dry and apply a thin engine dressing.

AVOID High pressure or direct water on electrical connectors.

DONE WHEN The bay is clean and evenly satin, not greasy.

D Headlight restoration (+\$40)

TOOLS / ITEMS Painter's tape Wet-sand kit (grits) Polish UV sealant

DO THIS Mask the paint around each lens. Wet-sand through the grits (coarse → fine), then machine- or hand-polish until clear. Clean, then apply the UV sealant and let it cure.

AVOID Skipping the UV sealant — without it the haze returns within weeks.

DONE WHEN The lenses are clear and sealed.

E**Ceramic coating upgrade (+\$120)**

TOOLS / ITEMS

Ceramic coating kit

Applicator block + suede

Panel-prep (IPA)

LED light

DO THIS

The paint must already be corrected and panel-wiped. Apply the coating to one small section in a cross-hatch, let it flash, then level it off with a fresh microfiber until clear. Inspect for high spots under the LED and buff them out. Keep the car dry for 24 hours.

AVOID

Working in sun, or letting a panel over-cure before levelling (permanent high spots).

DONE WHEN

Every panel is coated, levelled clear and streak-free.

F**Winter salt / undercarriage flush (+\$25)**

TOOLS / ITEMS

Salt neutralizer / undercarriage cleaner

Pressure washer

DO THIS

Flush the undercarriage, wheel wells and rockers, apply the salt neutralizer and let it dwell, then rinse thoroughly from underneath. Dry and dress the exposed wheel-well trim.

AVOID

High pressure at sensors and connectors.

DONE WHEN

Salt and grime are flushed and neutralized.

09 REFERENCE Vehicle size & dirt — adjusting the job

Bigger and dirtier vehicles take more time and product. The size surcharge covers that — judge it honestly when you book.

Size	Examples	Surcharge	What changes
Standard	Car · sedan · coupe	No charge	Baseline times in the plans.
Midsized	SUV · crossover · crew-cab truck	+\$20	More panels and glass, bigger interior — add ~20–30% time.
Oversized / extra-dirty	3-row SUV · lifted truck · heavy mud/pet/spills	+\$40	Third-row seating, more carpet, caked-on grime — plan extra wash, extraction and product.

- Quote the size surcharge and any add-ons **before** you start, never at payment.
- Extra-dirty standard cars can justify the oversized rate — it's about time and mess, not just size.
- Carry enough shampoo, microfiber and extractor solution for the biggest jobs of the day.

Common mistakes & how to fix them

Most problems come from rushing, working in the sun, or skipping a prep step. Here's how to diagnose and recover.

Problem	Usual cause	Fix / prevention
Swirls/scratches after washing	Dirty mitt, circular strokes, no grit guards	Two-bucket method, straight strokes, separate lower-panel mitt; a polish removes existing swirls.
Streaky glass	Wax residue on the towel, glass cleaned in sun, too much product	Dedicated glass towels, work in shade, spray onto the towel, buff with a dry waffle towel.
Water spots	Air-dried in the sun, hard water left to dry	Dry promptly in shade; for spots, clay or a light polish, then re-protect.
Dressing slinging onto paint	Too much tire dressing	Apply thin, wipe the edge, let it set before driving.
Headlights hazed again	UV sealant step skipped	Always finish restoration with UV sealant; re-do if needed.
Greasy/slippery leather	Too much conditioner, or APC used on leather	Use leather-specific products, apply thin, buff off the excess.
Musty smell after extraction	Fabric left too wet	Extra dry passes, fans/cracked windows; never over-wet padding.
Wax won't buff off	Applied too thick or left too long	Thin layers; if stuck, wipe with a quick-detailer and a fresh towel.
Holograms after polishing	Pad tilted or too much pressure	Keep the pad flat and moving; refine with a polishing pad + finishing polish.
Coating streaks (high spots)	Not levelled before curing	Level each section promptly; buff fresh high spots out before they cure.

Customer aftercare — what to tell them

A quick aftercare chat protects your work and earns repeat bookings. Tell every customer the basics, and more if you applied protection.

Every customer

- Skip harsh **automatic car washes** with stiff brushes — they re-scratch the paint. Hand wash, or use touchless.
- **Blot spills** in the interior, don't rub them in.
- Park in **shade** when you can to protect paint and interior.

If you waxed or sealed

- Wait **24 hours** before the next wash so the protection sets.
- Protection lasts weeks (wax) to months (sealant) — re-book to keep it topped up.

If you applied a ceramic coating

- Keep the car **dry for 24 hours** (no rain, no wash).
- Wait about **a week** for the coating to fully harden.
- Maintenance-wash with pH-neutral shampoo; no waxes needed on top.

Leave-behind card. "Thanks for choosing Detail Valley! Hand wash only for the next 24 hours, park in shade when you can, and blot any spills. Loved your detail? A quick 5-star review means the world — and tell a neighbour, we come to them too."

12 REFERENCE Glossary

The terms used in this handbook, in plain English.

APC	All-purpose cleaner — a dilutable interior/exterior cleaner.
Clay / claying	Using a clay bar with lube to pull bonded contaminants out of the paint.
Contact wash	The hands-on wash with a mitt, after the foam pre-wash.
Correction	Removing swirls and scratches with a machine polisher and compound.
Cross-hatch	Applying product up-down then left-right for even coverage (coatings).
DA polisher	Dual-action polisher — a beginner-safe machine that oscillates as it spins.
Decontamination	Removing bonded contaminants — iron remover (chemical) and clay (physical).
Dwell	Letting a product sit so it can work before you agitate or rinse.
Flash	The brief stage where a coating hazes/rainbows and is ready to level off.
Foam cannon	A pressure-washer attachment that coats the car in thick soap.
Grit guard	A grid in the bottom of a wash bucket that traps dirt away from the mitt.
High spot	Coating left un-levelled, leaving a streak that must be buffed before it cures.
Hologram	Fine circular marks left by poor machine technique.
IPA / panel-prep	A wipe that strips polishing oils so defects show and protection bonds.
One-step	A single correcting pass that combines cut and finish (~most light defects).
Sealant	A synthetic paint protection lasting months.
Sling	Tire/trim dressing flinging onto the paint while driving.
Swirls	Fine spider-web scratches from poor washing/drying.
Two-bucket method	Washing with separate soap and rinse buckets to keep grit off the mitt.
Water spot	A dried mineral mark from water left to evaporate in the sun.

13 REFERENCE

Quick-reference cards

Tear-out summaries for the van. When in doubt, the product label always wins over these starting points.

Order of operations (every job)

1. Set up & walk-around (photos)
2. Wheels, tires & wells
3. Bug/sap removal (Full+)
4. Foam pre-wash → two-bucket wash → rinse
5. Iron decon + clay (Full+)
6. Dry
7. Correct & protect (Showroom: polish → panel-prep → sealant)
8. Interior: vacuum → deep clean → shampoo/extract (Showroom)
9. Plastics & leather conditioned
10. Door jambs & trim
11. Glass in & out (last)
12. Final inspection → payment → review

Dwell times (starting points)

Product	Dwell	Note
Wheel cleaner	30–60 sec	Cool wheel only; don't let it dry.
Bug & tar remover	1–2 min	Agitate gently; keep wet.
Iron / fallout remover	3–5 min	Rinse before it dries; ventilate.
Foam pre-wash	2–3 min	Out of direct sun.
Wax/sealant haze	1–3 min	Buff at a light cloud.
Coating flash	30–90 sec	Then level — check label.

Towel colour code

- **Blue** — glass only
- **Green** — interior
- **Yellow** — wax, sealant & paint
- **Grey/old** — wheels & dirty jobs
- Wash separately · no fabric softener

Never do this

- Never dish soap on paint (strips protection).

- Never product on a hot/sunny panel.
- Never the same brush/mitt on wheels and paint.
- Never APC on real leather.
- Never high pressure at electronics or sensors.
- Never put carpet mats back wet.